

Rearing of Eri Silkworm

The Endi moth is a large moth with a wingspan ranging from 100 to 125 millimeters. Its wings are dark brown or blackish-brown and have a white band across the middle. Each wing contains a crescent-shaped yellow and white marking outlined in black. The abdomen of the male moth is narrower than that of the female, and after emerging from the cocoon, male moths are generally more active.

Following mating, the female moth lays between 300 and 500 eggs in clusters. The eggs are loosely wrapped in clean paper or cotton cloth and stored in a dark place to ensure uniform hatching. Newly hatched larvae are yellow with black body segments. The hatching period depends on temperature: eggs hatch within seven to ten days during summer and within twelve to fifteen days during winter.

The young larvae feed on tender leaves immediately after hatching. During the first instar stage, the larvae are fed soft leaves three to four times a day. After three or four days, they enter the moulting stage, during which they stop feeding and remain inactive for twenty-four to forty-eight hours while shedding their old skin to accommodate growth. Proper care is necessary during this period to avoid disturbance.

The larvae pass through five instar stages and undergo four moulting cycles. After each moult, they are fed fresh tender leaves. Moulting generally occurs every three or four days, during which feeding temporarily stops.

The first to third instar larvae, locally called **emphao**, are traditionally reared in bamboo trays known as **Songrai**, which are covered with cotton cloth. Leaves are spread over the trays so that the larvae can crawl and feed.

During the fourth and fifth instar stages, bunch rearing is practiced. In this method, six or seven twigs of host plants are tied together and placed horizontally on bamboo stands. Bamboo mats, trays, or cloths such as the traditional **dokhona** are spread underneath to collect waste and excreta.

Only mature leaves are provided to the growing larvae because feeding small leaves may reduce cocoon production. When the silkworm reaches maturity, it stops feeding and becomes translucent and restless as it searches for a place to spin its cocoon, known locally as **phithwb**.

At this stage, mature silkworms, called **emphao latha**, are collected by hand and placed on a support structure called a **mountage**, which is usually made from dry twigs. Leaves of white teak (**Gambhari**) are commonly used for making mountages. Overcrowding is avoided because it negatively affects cocoon quality.

The cocoons are harvested after pupation is complete, generally six to seven days after spinning. Harvesting is usually carried out by hand in the morning when the cocoons are still cool and moist.